FREE PRINTABLE

Label-Reading Cheat Sheet + 5 No-Sugar Spice Blends

Spot hidden sugars in seconds and add big flavour without sugar. From the Mix & Match Diabetes-Friendly Meal System.



Not medical advice. A general cooking and shopping aid. Talk to your care team about what's right for you.

Budget pantry & flavour without sugar

Budget pantry checklist

These cheap, long-lasting items show up again and again in the recipes. Keep them stocked and most meals only need one or two fresh items.

- [ ] black beans, canned (rinsed)
- [ ] low-sodium broth
- [ ] brown rice, cooked
- [ ] bulgur wheat, cooked
- [ ] chickpeas, canned (rinsed)
- [ ] red pepper flakes
- [ ] chili powder
- [ ] ground cinnamon
- [ ] corn tortillas (6-inch)
- [ ] whole-grain crackers
- [ ] ground cumin
- [ ] canned diced tomatoes
- [ ] everything-bagel seasoning
- [ ] garam masala or curry powder
- [ ] Italian seasoning or dried oregano
- [ ] jerk seasoning (salt-free if possible)
- [ ] lentils, cooked or canned (rinsed)
- [ ] mustard
- [ ] rolled oats
- [ ] smoked paprika
- [ ] natural peanut butter
- [ ] popcorn, air-popped
- [ ] salsa, no added sugar
- [ ] low-sodium soy sauce
- [ ] tomato paste
- [ ] canned tuna in water
- [ ] ground turmeric
- [ ] vanilla extract
- [ ] vinegar (any)
- [ ] white beans, canned (rinsed)
- [ ] whole-grain bread
- [ ] whole-wheat pasta, dry
- [ ] whole-wheat pita (6-inch)
- [ ] whole-wheat tortillas (8-inch)

Money savers: frozen vegetables, fish and berries cost less and don't spoil. Canned beans and lentils are the cheapest protein per serving. Plain oats cost a fraction of instant packets, and boneless chicken thighs are usually cheaper than breasts.

5 spice blends (no sugar)

Mix in a jar and use about 1 to 2 tsp per serving. Many store-bought blends contain sugar or starch, so check labels.

Taco / fajita

2 tbsp chili powder, 1 tbsp cumin, 1 tsp smoked paprika, 1 tsp garlic powder, 1 tsp oregano, 1/2 tsp salt

Use in: L03, D01, D04, D17

Everyday masala

1 tbsp garam masala or curry powder, 2 tsp cumin, 1 tsp turmeric, 1/2 tsp chili flakes, 1/2 tsp salt

Use in: B03, D05, D11, D15

Jerk-style

1 tbsp allspice, 1 tbsp dried thyme, 1 tsp each: garlic powder, onion powder, black pepper, cayenne, cinnamon

Use in: D08

Mediterranean herb

2 tbsp dried oregano, 1 tbsp dried basil, 1 tsp each: garlic powder, lemon zest (dried) and black pepper

Use in: L01, L10, D16

Smoky BBQ dry rub

2 tbsp smoked paprika, 1 tbsp cumin, 1 tsp each: garlic powder, onion powder, mustard powder, black pepper

Use in: D13, D19, S04

Label-reading cheat sheet

1. **Serving size first.** All the numbers on the label are for this amount. If you eat twice as much, double them.
2. **Total Carbohydrate.** This number includes starch, sugars and fiber. It's the number most carb counters use.
3. **Dietary Fiber.** More fiber usually means the food is more filling. Whole-grain and bean products tend to be higher.
4. **Added Sugars.** Shown under Total Sugars on US labels. Compare brands and choose the lower one.
5. **Ingredients list.** Ingredients are listed by weight. If a sugar is in the first three, the product is mostly sugar.

Labels in the UK and EU often list carbohydrate *without* fiber, so figures can look lower than US labels for the same food. Check the label's format before comparing.

Other names for sugar

cane sugar · brown sugar · honey · agave · maple syrup · corn syrup · high-fructose corn syrup · dextrose · glucose · maltose · sucrose · fruit juice concentrate · rice syrup · molasses · maltodextrin · evaporated cane juice · coconut sugar · barley malt

Watch the "health halo"

- "Sugar-free" can still be high in starch (carbs).
- "Multigrain" doesn't mean whole grain. Look for "100% whole" in the first ingredient.
- "Natural" and "organic" don't mean low in sugar.
- Granola, smoothies, flavoured yogurt and "protein" bars often have a lot of added sugar.